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10.4 Transportation



Focus Questions:

- *When is it the least expensive to travel by air?*
- *What is the advantage of rail travel in the US?*
- *How can international students legally drive in the US?*

Domestic Airlines

With more than 5,000 public airports, the domestic air travel system in the US is large and reliable. Although flying is more expensive than other modes of transportation, it is the quickest way to travel across North America.

Most US carriers provide online booking services and offer a range of prices for flights. To find the best flight (e.g., at the right cost and departure/arrival times), students can consult popular travel websites such as Orbitz,

Travelocity, Expedia, Kayak, etc. Flying midweek and between fall and spring (excluding holidays) tends to be less expensive.

Before a flight, it is a good idea to consult the Transportation Security Administration (TSA) online at www.tsa.gov and the airline's website for information about required identification, baggage restrictions and rules for carry-ons.

Rail Travel

Amtrak provides passenger rail service in the US: www.amtrak.com. Trains are not usually the most cost-effective or quickest option for long-distance travel, but they can offer a memorable tourism experience.

The Acela Express – Amtrak's high-speed rail service along the Northeast corridor – links Boston, New York, Philadelphia, Baltimore, and Washington, DC. Other commuter rail lines are found near Chicago, major West Coast cities, and around Miami.

Bus and Subway Travel

Bus travel in the US includes either long-distance vehicles or local transit.

Travel by bus is a relatively inexpensive option to get between major towns and cities. Greyhound is the primary long-distance bus company, serving much of the US. It offers several types of passes and discount options for students. Trailways is another long-distance bus carrier that offers competitive fares and regional services.

- Greyhound: www.greyhound.com
- Trailways: www.trailways.com

Most cities and larger towns have reliable local bus systems, although service may be limited during evenings and on weekends. Fares can range from \$1 to \$3 per ride but may be more expensive during the busiest hours as well as in bigger cities.

Subway systems are found in major US cities – including New York, Boston, Chicago, and Los Angeles, among others. The subway is a cheap and quick way of getting around. Most transit systems offer discounted rates to frequent riders and students.

Bicycle

A bicycle can be a good option for traveling around campus and a student's local area. Students may be able to find a used bike for purchase by looking at advertisements on campus bulletin boards or listings on websites like Craigslist, and some campuses rent out bikes to students, often for the duration of a term. When biking, it's important to observe the rules of the road and wear a helmet: it is mandatory to wear one in some US states. More tips:

- Exercise caution cycling on city streets. Use bicycle paths and lanes whenever possible and remember to keep on the right side of the road.
- Purchase a bike lock and secure your bike when not using it. There are many bike racks on college campuses for that purpose.

Driving in the US

For information about driving, international students should contact their university or college and the Department of Motor Vehicles in the state where they will be living. As noted on the "Study in the States" website of the US Department of Homeland Security (DHS):

"The United States is made up of 50 states and six territories; each has its own department of motor vehicles (DMV), laws, and ways of doing things. The term DMV is a general term; some states call the DMV something else, such as the Motor Vehicle Administration, Department of Transportation, or Department of Safety/State. Check with your DSO [designated school official] or RO [responsible officer] to find out what your state calls a DMV."

If a student has a valid driver's license from their home country and an International Driving Permit (IDP), they may be able to legally drive in the US. They should check with the aforementioned agencies to confirm. An IDP translates the information contained on a student's official driver's license into 10 languages. The United States *does not* issue IDPs to foreign visitors, so students will need to obtain this document in their home country *before* they travel to the US.

Nevertheless, students might want to obtain a local driver's license, which is a commonly used form of identification; it is also more familiar to authorities. In some cases, they will be required to get a local license.

For full details on how international students can apply for a driver's licence, please visit this government website [<https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/students/study/driving-in-the-united-states>].

Car Rentals

Students can rent a car in the US only if they are 25 or older. They may need to show both their license and an IDP to rent a car. Research the rental company's policies in advance.

Road Rules and Driving Tips

- Throughout the US all traffic drives on the right side of the road.
- Seat belts for drivers and all passengers must be worn in the front and back of the vehicle, and infants must be strapped into a safety seat.
- Unless otherwise indicated, speed limits in city areas are usually 25mph to 35mph, except for in school zones where the speed limit can be as low as 15mph. On highways, the speed limit is usually 55mph to 65mph, although it is sometimes raised to 75mph on interstate highways.
- Turning right on a red light is allowed at an intersection except where there are signs prohibiting it, and in New York City where it is illegal.
- Drivers must always carry their license and vehicle documentation.
- Do not text and drive: texting while driving is banned in the US. If a student must take a phone call, they should use a headset.
- If a student owns a car, they must have car insurance.

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